

Passages - There are Places in the World Where rules are less important than Kindness

There is no science without Imagination,
and No Art without Facts:

A writer must have the precision of a poet
and the imagination of a scientist

I discovered in nature the nonutilitarian
delights that I sought in art.

How beautiful youth is, how nonetheless
fleeting! Let anyone seeking happiness
enjoy it: tomorrow brings nothing but
uncertainty ...

Petrarch had begun the previous century
by writing that:

'The works of the past are like the flowers
from which bees collect nectar to make
honey?

Dreams have a tendency to seem
inconceivable as soon as they are over. But
history shows that it is sometimes some of
the most apparently inconceivable dreams
that become reality.

It is the fantasy of those who rule that
nothing will change.

Sometimes, like children who are afraid of
the dark, we fear in the light of day things
as inconsistent as those that the child is
afraid of at night.

Dante says intriguingly that this other part
of the universe surrounds the first in a
circle, like the first surrounds the others',
and in the next canto refers to it as
'appearing to be enclosed by that which it

encloses. The point of light and the spheres of angels surround the universe, and at the same time are surrounded by it.

Lack of familiarity with statistical thinking is widespread even among the educated, and it is deleterious.

Probability does not refer to the system as such, but to the knowledge that I have about this system. I am characterizing my degree of knowledge/ignorance of the state of the atmosphere. This is what probability is all about.

Karl Popper exerted an immense influence upon scientists when he maintained that science is not characterized by the fact that its theories have proved to be true, but only by the fact that they can be proved to be false. This means that there is nothing that we can know with certainty.

Science, understood as the discoverer of absolute truth. remains therefore, naturally, a source of disillusion for its lack of absolute truths. If the cold marble idol of a perfect, eternal and universal science that we could only seek to better understand falls and shatters, it is there that suddenly alongside it we find a living creature, a science that our thought freely creates. A living entity: flesh of our flesh, the fruit of our torment, our companion in the struggle

It is probability that makes life interesting. It is because of probability that we can be touched by the unexpected. It is probability that allows us to remain open to further knowledge. We are limited and mortal, we can learn to accept the limits of our knowledge - but we can still aim to learn and to look for the foundation of this

knowledge. It is not certainty.
It is reliability.

Philosophical thought opens windows, frees us from prejudices, reveals incongruities and leaps of logic, suggests new methodological approaches, and in general opens up the minds of scientists to new possibilities. It has always done so in the past, and it continues to do so.

The octopus is an extremely distant relative. The octopus, in short, is the extra-terrestrial that we have been looking for in order to study a possible independent realization of consciousness.

Different forms of consciousness.

What interests us about octopoid intellectual complexity is not just the similarities with our own, it is also the differences between the two types. The neural structure of an octopus is different from ours: instead of being concentrated in a brain, it is articulated throughout its entire body, including its arms, diffused just below the surface of its body. It is a complex but radically alien intelligence.

New ideas do not just fall from the sky. They are born from a deep immersion in contemporary knowledge. From making that knowledge intensely your own, to the point where you are living immersed in it. From endlessly turning over the open questions, trying all roads to a solution, then again trying all the roads to a solution - and then trying all those roads again. Until there, where we least expected it, we discover a gap, a fissure, a way through.

Intelligence is not about stubborn adherence to your own opinions. It

requires readiness to change and even discard those opinions.

What's important is not being right. It's to try to understand.

A declaration of faith in the knowability of the world, and a proud rebuke to those who are content with their own ignorance and with delegating knowledge elsewhere.

The farce of Sacred National Identity, is a useful strategy, regardless of how fake it is.

Forged in order to reduce internal conflicts, it ends up provoking external ones that are even more damaging.

There is no such thing as intentionality in nature. It isn't design that directs the combination of things, but it is the combination of things that gave rise to intentionality

With the discovery of radioactivity, of its chemical and physical properties and its medical uses, Marie Curie opened the gates to the great science of the twentieth century.

Lemaître was uninterested in taking the credit for the discovery. His message seems to me the deepest and clearest that science has managed to articulate: don't take yourselves too seriously; stay humble. Even if your name is Einstein, even if you are the Pope himself. Even if you are 'The Master'.

Nothing has existence in itself. Everything exists only through dependence on something else, in relation to something else.

'I' is nothing other than the vast and interconnected set of phenomena that constitute it, each one dependent on something else.

Astronomy gives him means for this escape from the self, and to journey towards the infinite. To look up at the heavens and to speak with the stars

Leopardi feels close to us because he speaks the language he heart when it is lost, disillusioned, naked before the truth.

To interpret language as something that necessarily 'refers' to something external is to create false metaphysical problems.

A main source of the emotions that give power to the right, and above all to the far right, is not the feeling of being strong. It is, on the contrary, the fear of being weak.

Those who are strong are not afraid, do not seek conflict but collaborate instead, and contribute to building a better world, for themselves and others. If someone tells you that you should be afraid, it is because they are weak.

The clusters of galaxies will recede from each other at increasing speeds, stars will be extinguished, everything will be reduced to a few black holes and light waves wandering in an ever more boundless and glacial space. With the lapse of eons of time, black holes themselves will end up evaporating and there will be nothing left but a universe of waves of light racing through nothingness for all eternity.

An immensely expanded universe is in

reality the same as an infinitely small universe.

Whoever says that we cannot have absolute certainty about the future climate of the planet is stating an obvious truth. But it is obtuse to say that a danger is not grave because it is not mathematically certain that it will happen.

If we discover a bomb that has remained buried beneath what is now a children's playground, we do not leave it there because "it might not explode.

In Italy, the philosophers of the school of Elea, following in the footsteps of Parmenides, had taken this intuition to a radical extreme, maintaining that true reality is only what can be reconstructed by reason, therefore denying reality to mere appearances.

I don't like emotion produced by nature because God has made it so beautiful. I like to feel moved by it because it is beautiful.

I am speechless: there are places in the world where rules are less important than kindness.

And every Christmas, whether we are fervent Catholics or outright atheists, we go home to see our ageing parents, and exchange presents with our friends. And so the year and the world turns in an orderly fashion: we are reassured that the ties of affection hold us together, we feel at home in the world. We are ready for life to begin again.

We are not the masters of the world, we are not immortal; we are, as we have always been, like leaves in the autumn

wind. We are not waging a battle against death. That battle we must inevitably lose, as death prevails anyway. What we are doing is struggling, together, to buy one another more days on Earth. For this short life, despite everything, seems beautiful to us, now more than ever.